

Diceros bicornis

Black rhinoceros



Location W., C., E. and southern Africa
Status Critically endangered

Length 9½–10 ft (2.9–3.1 m)
Tail 23 ½ in (60 cm)
Weight 1–1¼ tons (0.9–1.3 tonnes)
Social unit Individual



Browsing on a variety of bushes and low trees, the black rhinoceros occupies a variety of habitats but mainly wooded savanna with mosaics of grass and trees. As in other rhinoceros species, its sight is poor but hearing and smell excellent. It feeds mainly by twilight and at night; days are spent dozing in shade or wallowing in mud. The black rhinoceros is solitary, and marks its home range with piles of dung and copious squirts of urine. It may tolerate intruders (of its own species, or human), but this unpredictable rhinoceros may suddenly charge or jab with its horns. Two black rhinoceroses together are usually a mating pair, associating for just a few days, or a mother and calf. The female gives birth after 15–16 months' gestation. The newborn weighs 88 lb (40 kg), begins to take solid food after a few weeks, and is weaned at around 2 years.

PREHENSILE LIP



The black rhinoceros, also known as the hook-lipped rhinoceros, has a pointed, prehensile upper lip. This curls around new twigs and shoots to draw them into the mouth, where they are bitten off by the molar teeth.

front horn up to 4½ ft (1.4 m) long

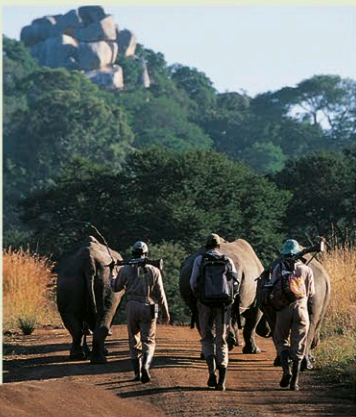
GRAY SKIN, BLACK APPEARANCE

The black rhinoceros's skin is gray with hairs only on the eyelashes, ear tips, and tail end. Its dark appearance is the result of mud dried on the skin.



CONSERVATION

Intense demand for rhinoceros horn for traditional oriental medicines and for dagger handles and similar items in the Middle East led to a massive decline in black rhinoceros numbers from 65,000 in 1970 to just 2,500 in the mid-1990s. Since then, its numbers have increased to 4,880 in 2007, with 240 in captivity. Many of the wild animals are protected from poachers by 24-hour armed guards.



Ceratotherium simum

White rhinoceros



Location E. and southern Africa
Status Near threatened

Length 12–13 ft (3.7–4 m)
Tail 28 in (70 cm)
Weight Up to 2.5 tons (2.3 tonnes)
Social unit Group



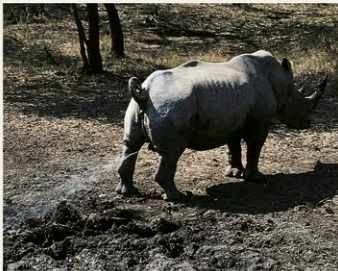
The largest and most numerous rhinoceros, the white rhinoceros rivals the hippopotamus as the biggest land animal after the elephant. Males weigh up to half a ton more than females, and have longer horns and a more pronounced nuchal crest. The front horn may reach 4¼ ft (1.3 m) in length, the rear one 16 in (40 cm). This is also the most social rhinoceros, generally placid, with mother–calf pairs staying together for long periods and up to 7 juveniles forming small herds. Mature males, however, tend to be solitary.

An almost exclusive grazer, the wide, straight upper lip—giving the alternative name of square-lipped rhinoceros—and hard lip pads crop grass extremely close. Populations of southern white rhinoceroses (*Ceratotherium simum simum*) are reasonably secure, numbering nearly 18,000, although still conservation-dependent. There may be fewer than 30 of the critically endangered northern white rhinoceroses (*Ceratotherium simum cottoni*).

HUMPED SHOULDER

The prominent nuchal crest behind the ears is formed by the bones, muscles, and ligaments to support the huge head.

URINE-MARKING



A male rhinoceros's penis faces the rear, so urine sprays out between the back legs. Male white rhinoceroses mark home ranges in this way. Each needs a territory of about ½ square mile (1 square km) to be selected for breeding.

CONSERVATION

A rhinoceros's horns can be quickly and painlessly removed under anesthetic, thereby removing the reason for poachers to kill them. It was thought to have no effect on the rhino, however, it has been suggested that mothers cannot defend their calves effectively without their horns. Injecting horns with toxins was also tried in some places without success.

